



For your early adopters

Discipleship group starter kit



A training kit for launching Christian discipleship groups among your staff and volunteers. It starts with the pitfalls that sink most groups, then gives you a six-session training plan, a weekly group rhythm and a covenant your early adopters can use from week one.

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Overview

What are small groups at Citychurch?

Small groups of 8 to 10 adults who meet weekly around Scripture, prayer and honest accountability, with a plan to multiply from day one.

Groups of 8 to 10 are small enough that everyone can speak each week and large enough that a couple of absences never stall the meeting. For the accountability portion, break into pairs or threes so the depth of a very small group is not lost inside the bigger one.

Group size	8 to 10 adults
Meets	Weekly, about 1 hour and 15 minutes
Covenant term	9 to 12 months, then each member is encouraged to start a group
Early adopter training	6 sessions of about 90 minutes
Who	Staff and volunteers who choose to join

Assumptions behind this kit

- Broadly evangelical, Bible-centered, and not tied to one denomination. Adjust wording to your tradition.
- Groups are 8 to 10 adults. The sources behind some pitfalls studied very small groups of 3 or 4, so watch how depth holds at this size and lean on the pair-and-three breakouts.
- Early adopters are 6 to 12 staff and volunteers who will each facilitate or co-facilitate a group afterward.
- Training meets in person, weekly or every other week.
- Groups are separate from anyone's job. Joining is voluntary.



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12 pitfalls and their guardrails

These come up again and again across church research, ministry leaders and practitioners. Number 10 matters most for a workplace like yours.

1. It turns into a Bible study

What it looks like. Great discussion, lots of learning, little change. People leave knowing more but living the same.

Guardrail. Every meeting ends with each person naming one specific step of obedience (James 1:22). Next week starts by asking how it went.

JAMES 1:22

²² But be doers of the word, and not only hearers, deluding your own selves.

Sources: Christian Today, 4 pitfalls (2016) · UMC Discipleship, the trouble with small groups (2016) · Blake Chrisman, why D-groups stop making disciples (2020)

2. It turns into a support group

What it looks like. The whole hour goes to problems and venting. Care is real, but Scripture and growth get crowded out.

Guardrail. Care for each other, then bring each need to the Word and to prayer. Refer deeper needs (grief, marriage, addiction, mental health) to a pastor or counselor.

Sources: Lifeway Research, 5 elements (2015) · Christian Today, 4 pitfalls (2016)

3. Catch-up eats the meeting

What it looks like. Highs and lows run 30 minutes, and prayer gets the last two.

Guardrail. Use the timed meeting rhythm in the Toolkit and rotate a timekeeper.

Sources: Discipleship.org, 7 pitfalls · Blake Chrisman, why D-groups stop making disciples (2020)

4. Accountability is either soft or forced

What it looks like. Soft: everyone says "fine" and nobody asks again. Forced: a new or shy member is pushed to confess before trust exists.

Guardrail. Sign a covenant so accountability is invited, not imposed. The facilitator goes first in honesty. Let depth grow with trust.

Sources: Discipleship.org, 7 pitfalls · Christian Today, 4 pitfalls (2016) · Greg Ogden, C.S. Lewis Institute (2008)

5. One hero leader carries everything

What it looks like. The group depends on one strong person. When their life changes, the group falls apart, and nobody else feels qualified to lead.

Guardrail. Everyone points to Christ, not the leader. Recruit a co-facilitator from inside the group and rotate facilitation from month two, so leadership is shared across the group.

Sources: Baptist Press, 7 silent killers (Feb 2026) · Greg Ogden, C.S. Lewis Institute (2008)

6. No plan to multiply

What it looks like. The group is healthy and closed. Two years on, it is the same people and no new groups.

Guardrail. Name multiplication in the first meeting. Set an end date in the covenant. A group of 8 to 10 multiplies by splitting into two groups of 4 or 5 and inviting new members. Before the end date, each member names who they will invite.

Sources: Baptist Press, 7 silent killers (Feb 2026) · Lifeway Research, 5 elements (2015) · GoMicro, dangers to discipling (2024)

7. No clear win

What it looks like. People cannot say what the group is for, so each person defines growth on their own terms.

Guardrail. Teach the five marks of a disciple (Session 2) and review them together every quarter.

Sources: Lifeway Research, why plans stall (Apr 2026) · Baptist Press, 7 silent killers (Feb 2026)

8. Commitment slides

What it looks like. Missed weeks, skipped reading, "I didn't get to it." It spreads to the whole group.

Guardrail. Put attendance and prep in the covenant. When it slips, revisit the covenant together kindly and early.

Sources: Discipleship.org, 7 pitfalls · Baptist Press, 7 silent killers (Feb 2026)

9. Drifting from Scripture

What it looks like. Shortcuts creep in, like dropping memory verses, or one member steers the group toward a favorite book or idea.

Guardrail. Keep a shared Bible reading plan as the core text. Facilitators check in monthly with the ministry lead.

Sources: GoMicro, dangers to disciplemaking (2024) · Discipleship.org, 7 pitfalls

10. Your boss is in your group

What it looks like. A staff member shares a struggle in group, and it later colors how their supervisor sees their work. People stop being honest.

Guardrail. Never place a supervisor and a direct report in the same group. Participation is voluntary and never comes up in performance reviews.

Source: The awkward trinity of ministry roles (Feb 2026)

11. Care turns into control

What it looks like. Guilt, pressure, rigid rules, a leader seen as more spiritual than others, and people who feel they cannot leave.

Guardrail. Anyone can step out without penalty. Facilitators are accountable to the ministry lead. Encourage people to test everything against Scripture themselves.

Source: Probe Ministries, spiritual abuse

12. Mixed-gender groups stay shallow

What it looks like. Members hold back on the things that most need talking about.

Guardrail. Keep groups at 8 to 10 people, and use same-gender pairs or threes for the accountability portion.

Source: GoMicro, dangers to disciplemaking (2024)



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Six sessions for early adopters

Each session runs about 90 minutes: 15 minutes of welcome and prayer, 40 minutes of teaching and discussion, 25 minutes of practice, and 10 minutes to set homework and pray. The goal is for every early adopter to have been in a group, not just heard about one.

Session 1: Why we make disciples

Scripture	Matthew 28:18-20 · 2 Timothy 2:2 · Mark 3:14
Goal	Share the vision and why it fits who you are.

MATTHEW 28:18-20

¹⁸ Jesus came to them and spoke to them, saying, “All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth. ¹⁹ Go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, ²⁰ teaching them to observe all things that I commanded you. Behold, I am with you always, even to the end of the age.” Amen.

2 TIMOTHY 2:2

² The things which you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit the same things to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.

MARK 3:14

¹⁴ He appointed twelve, that they might be with him, and that he might send them out to preach,

Cover

- Jesus called the twelve first to be with him, then to be sent. Discipleship is relationship before it is program.
- Paul to Timothy: four generations in one verse. We train people who will train others.
- Our tie-in: we feed hungry children because bread matters. We disciple our staff and volunteers because people do not live by bread alone (Deuteronomy 8:3, Matthew 4:4). Jesus is the bread of life (John 6:35).

DEUTERONOMY 8:3

³ He humbled you, allowed you to be hungry, and fed you with manna, which you didn’t know, neither did your fathers know, that he might teach you that man does not live by bread only, but man lives by every word that proceeds out of Yahweh’s mouth.

MATTHEW 4:4

⁴ But he answered, “It is written, ‘Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceeds out of God’s mouth.’”

JOHN 6:35

³⁵ Jesus said to them, “I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will not be hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty.

Practice. Each person shares who has discipled them, formally or not, and what that person did.

Homework. Read Mark 1-3. Write your faith story in a form you could tell in 3 minutes.

Session 2: What a disciple is

Scripture	Luke 9:23 · John 15:1-11 · Acts 2:42
Goal	Agree on a clear win the whole ministry can name.

LUKE 9:23

²³ He said to all, “If anyone desires to come after me, let him deny himself, take up his cross, and follow me.

JOHN 15:1-11

¹ “I am the true vine, and my Father is the farmer. ² Every branch in me that doesn’t bear fruit, he takes away. Every branch that bears fruit, he prunes, that it may bear more fruit. ³ You are already pruned clean because of the word which I have spoken to you. ⁴ Remain in me, and I in you. As the branch can’t bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine, so neither can you, unless you remain in me. ⁵ I am the vine. You are the branches. He who remains in me and I in him bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing. ⁶ If a man doesn’t remain in me, he is thrown out as a branch and is withered; and they gather them, throw them into the fire, and they are burned. ⁷ If you remain in me, and my words remain in you, you will ask whatever you desire, and it will be done for you. ⁸ “In this my Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit; and so you will be my disciples. ⁹ Even as the Father has loved me, I also have loved you. Remain in my love. ¹⁰ If you keep my commandments, you will remain in my love, even as I have kept my Father’s commandments and remain in his love. ¹¹ I have spoken these things to you, that my joy may remain in you, and that your joy may be made full.

ACTS 2:42

⁴² They continued steadfastly in the apostles’ teaching and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and prayer.

Cover

- Five marks of a growing disciple: abides in the Word, prays, lives in honest community, obeys what Jesus says, and joins his mission, including through the work we do for kids.
- Growth is the fruit of abiding in Christ, not self-improvement.
- Why Scripture memory matters, and how to start small.

Practice. Tell your 3-minute faith stories in pairs. Give each other one encouragement.

Homework. Start the daily reading plan. Memorize John 15:5.

Session 3: How a group works

Scripture	Hebrews 10:24-25 · Acts 2:42-47
Goal	Experience a real group meeting from start to finish.

HEBREWS 10:24-25

²⁴ Let's consider how to provoke one another to love and good works, ²⁵ not forsaking our own assembling together, as the custom of some is, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching.

ACTS 2:42-47

⁴² They continued steadfastly in the apostles' teaching and fellowship, in the breaking of bread, and prayer. ⁴³ Fear came on every soul, and many wonders and signs were done through the apostles. ⁴⁴ All who believed were together, and had all things in common. ⁴⁵ They sold their possessions and goods, and distributed them to all, according as anyone had need. ⁴⁶ Day by day, continuing steadfastly with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread at home, they took their food with gladness and singleness of heart, ⁴⁷ praising God and having favor with all the people. The Lord added to the assembly day by day those who were being saved.

Cover

- Walk through the weekly rhythm in the Toolkit.
- The trainer leads a full live meeting with the cohort as members.
- Debrief: what helped, what felt awkward, what you would change.

Practice. Split into threes and practice the Scripture section using this week's reading.

Homework. Continue reading. Write down one step of obedience and try it this week.

Session 4: Pitfalls and guardrails

Scripture	Galatians 6:1-2 · Proverbs 27:17
Goal	See the common failure points before your groups hit them.

GALATIANS 6:1-2

¹Brothers, even if a man is caught in some fault, you who are spiritual must restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness, looking to yourself so that you also aren't tempted. ²Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.

PROVERBS 27:17

¹⁷Iron sharpens iron; so a man sharpens his friend's countenance.

Cover

- Walk through the 12 pitfalls in the Pitfalls section.
- Which two worry you most for our ministry? Why?
- Work through the case studies in the Toolkit.

Practice. Role-play two case studies. Rotate who plays the facilitator.

Homework. Read the covenant draft and mark anything you would change.

Session 5: Accountability, confidentiality and care

Scripture	James 5:16 · Proverbs 27:6 · 1 Thessalonians 2:8
Goal	Build trust that is safe and honest.

JAMES 5:16

¹⁶Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The insistent prayer of a righteous person is powerfully effective.

PROVERBS 27:6

⁶The wounds of a friend are faithful, although the kisses of an enemy are profuse.

1 THESSALONIANS 2:8

⁸Even so, affectionately longing for you, we were well pleased to impart to you not the Good News of God only, but also our own souls, because you had become very dear to us.

Cover

- Finalize the group covenant together.

- Confidentiality and its limits: anything suggesting harm to self or others, or abuse of a child, is not kept confidential. Follow your organization's child protection policy and state reporting law.
- When to refer someone to a pastor or counselor.
- The supervisor rule, and why participation stays voluntary.

Practice. Practice the accountability questions in threes. The facilitator answers first.

Homework. Pray over your list of people you might invite into a group.

Session 6: Sent to multiply

Scripture	2 Timothy 2:2 · John 20:21
Goal	Launch the first groups.

2 TIMOTHY 2:2

²The things which you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit the same things to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.

JOHN 20:21

²¹Jesus therefore said to them again, “Peace be to you. As the Father has sent me, even so I send you.”

Cover

- Form the first groups: 8 to 10 adults, no supervisor with a direct report.
- Set a start date, meeting time and covenant end date for each group.
- Name who each person will pray about inviting when their group multiplies.

Practice. Lay hands on and pray over each new facilitator in a short commissioning.

Homework. Hold your first group meeting within two weeks.



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Toolkit

Weekly meeting rhythm (about 1 hour and 15 minutes)

Scripture	What did you read? What does it show about God? About us? What will you do?	35 min
Memory verse	Say it to each other.	5 min
Accountability	Break into pairs or threes and use 3 to 5 questions from the list below.	20 min
Mission and prayer	Who are you praying for and serving? Pray for each other by name.	15 min

Accountability questions

Pick 3 to 5 as a group and use the same ones for a season.

1. How has your time in God's Word been this week?
2. What step of obedience did you name last week, and how did it go?
3. Where have you seen God at work, including in our work with kids?

4. Is there anything you need to confess or bring into the light?
 5. Who are you praying for who does not yet know Jesus?
 6. How are your closest relationships: family, friends, coworkers?
 7. How are you resting and caring for yourself?
 8. Have you been honest in your answers today?
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Group covenant

Read it together and have each member sign. Fill in the blanks as a group.

- We will meet every _____ at _____ from _____ until _____.
 - We will come prepared: reading done, memory verse practiced.
 - We will pray for each other by name during the week.
 - We will be honest, and we will let each other grow in honesty at our own pace.
 - What is shared here stays here, except anything suggesting harm to self or others or abuse of a child, which we will bring to the right people.
 - This group has nothing to do with anyone's job or volunteer role. No one is evaluated on it.
 - Anyone may step out at any time without penalty.
 - Before our end date, each of us will pray about who we could invite into a new group.
-

Case studies for Session 4

1. One member talks for 20 minutes during every check-in. How do you redirect with kindness?
2. Your group has skipped memory verses for three weeks. Does it matter? What do you do?
3. A member wants to swap the reading plan for a popular Christian book everyone is talking about.
4. A staff member's supervisor asks to join their group.
5. During prayer, a member shares something that suggests a child may be at risk.
6. Six months in, the group loves meeting and does not want to multiply.

Facilitator checklist

- Pray for each member by name before the meeting.
- Do the reading yourself first.
- Watch the clock so prayer never gets squeezed.
- Go first in honesty.
- Follow up with anyone who missed.
- Check in monthly with the ministry lead.
- Recruit a co-facilitator from inside the group by month two, and hand them facilitation at least once a month.

Before launch. Have someone review the confidentiality wording against your organization's child protection policy and your state's reporting rules, since your staff and volunteers work with children.

Sources

The pitfalls come from these sources. The training plan, meeting rhythm, questions and covenant are a synthesis built on them.

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Researched 23 Sep 2026. Scripture quotations are from the World English Bible (WEB), which is in the public domain. Read them alongside the translation you use.